

 Department of Children & Family Services <i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i>	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-300-STEP Case Management Process
	Document No./Name	P-390-STEP Family Success Agreement
	Effective Date	February 15, 2024

I. STATEMENT OF POLICY

Upon determination of eligibility and after completion of the Family Assessment, work-eligible FITAP recipients shall *** * complete an individual responsibility plan, known as the Family Success Agreement, with the department.

The Family Success Agreement (FSA) is comprised of two parts: a rights and responsibilities agreement, and the mutually-developed goal plan between a STEP participant, on behalf of their family, and the department.

The FSA is the tool used to ensure that STEP participants are engaged in activities and making progress towards their career pathway, full potential, and/or financial independence.

The Agreement advises the participant of their rights and responsibilities, and the results of noncompliance. Additionally, the form requires the participant's assurances and signature.

Completion of the Agreement is required only once, which occurs after the participant has completed their portion of the Family Assessment. Once the STEP Coach has engaged the participant using the Family Assessment, the participant is ready for goal setting using the FSA Goal Plan.

The FSA Goal Plan is a working document that requires the participant to set:

- a long-term goal working towards a career pathway, their full potential, and/or financial independence,
- short-term goal(s),
- specific action step(s) to achieve their short-term goal(s),
- a timeframe for achieving their short-term goal(s),
- their definition of success related to achieving the short-term goal(s), and
- the supportive services needed to achieve their short-term goal(s).

The FSA and FSA Goal Plan are to be completed in TuaPath.

The FSA Goal Plan may be updated as changes are needed. The initial FSA Goal Plan and all subsequent FSA goal plans will become part of the participant's agreement.

STEP Coaches will use the agreement and the FSA Goal Plan as tools to:

- Help the participant understand that participation in STEP work activities will help them realize their full potential.
- Help the participant understand the long-term goal will lead to a career pathway, their full potential, and/or financial independence.
- Use Goal4It! techniques to engage and support the participant.
- Help the participant understand the short-term goal(s) helps them achieve the long-term goal.
- Talk about the participant's strengths, as determined in the Family Assessment, which can be built upon.

 Department of Children & Family Services <i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i>	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-300-STEP Case Management Process
	Document No./Name	P-390-STEP Family Success Agreement
	Effective Date	February 15, 2024

- Document the action steps the participant has agreed to do. This is essential to holding the participant responsible for their participation.
- Help the participant identify potholes that may disrupt participation and detours to overcome and get through a specific pothole.
- Offer suggestions, if the client is open to suggestions, to keep the participant moving towards independence, by reminding those who are seeking a career pathway (who are not job-ready) that short-term goal(s) should eventually lead towards becoming job-ready.
- Help disabled participants select short-term goal(s) and activities that will help them stabilize. Short-term goal(s) and work activities may look and feel very different for disabled participants based on their individual needs, but the long-term goal should set them on the path towards financial independence.
- Document potholes and detours related to the participant's goal.
- Inform participants of the supports that are available to them.
- Ask the participant to identify an accountability partner.
- Help participants identify other support systems or resources such as family or friends and how they can be used to ensure success.
- Inform participants when their TuaPath time sheets and supporting documents are due.

After an FSA Goal Plan has been signed, the STEP Coach must work with the participants to understand how their benefits will be impacted by their involvement in the goal plan and their engagement in activities that lead to work or self-sufficiency.

STEP Coaches will set the participant's beginning participation level to meet them where they are. Once appropriate, based upon the participant's increased education, skills and/or opportunities, the STEP Coach must set the expectation that hours of activities will add up to full-time participation (20-30 hours per week). The STEP coach must work with the participant to identify the hours of activities that will add to full participation.

The STEP Coach must ensure the participant understands what constitutes job readiness and how it may impact their benefits if employment is not accepted. The STEP Coach must document in Person Notes once the participant's achieves job-ready status. The participant must find and accept employment once they are job-ready.

STEP Coaches must also closely monitor the participant's engagement in goal setting, activities, and progress. If the client's failure to participate is related to required work activities, the STEP Coach should immediately begin a Review and Revise session when the participant is failing to participate as agreed upon, or failing to timely verify their participation hours, progress, or success.

Face to face contact is important to engage participants. STEP Coaches should meet in person for the FSA Goal Plan as often as possible. If a STEP Coach is authorized to travel and meets a client away from their normal work site for an FSA appointment, a manual FSA (STEP 6) may be completed if they do not have online access. The completed manual FSA (STEP 6) must be saved in OnBase and the FSA Goal Plan details must be entered online in TuaPath.

 Department of Children & Family Services <i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i>	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-300-STEP Case Management Process
	Document No./Name	P-390-STEP Family Success Agreement
	Effective Date	February 15, 2024

STEP Coaches are required to document the client's activities and progress in Person Notes. These notes should be timely entered. The purpose is to ensure participants are receiving opportunities to succeed in the program and proof that the STEP Coach is actively engaging the participant. Instances of good cause must be documented to explain why the participant is not participating.

Unless Good Cause is verified, failure to complete and sign the Family Success Agreement Rights and Responsibilities and/or FSA Goal Plan(s), without good cause, will result in ineligibility for the participant and a STEP sanction (Refer to P-500-STEP).

After an FSA Goal Plan has been signed, compliance in STEP will be measured by the participant's progress towards achieving their self-sufficiency goals. (See P-500-STEP for additional details.)

If a participant leaves the program and reapplies a new Family Success Agreement Rights and Responsibilities and FSA Goal Plan shall be completed.

II. PROCEDURES

Upon certification, initiate contact with the family within one week to ensure completion of the FSA and FSA Goal Plan within 10 days of FITAP certification.

The FSA Rights and Responsibilities and FSA Goal Plan should be completed face-to-face, but can be completed by phone to avoid a hardship for the participant. Participants may log in and sign their FSA Rights and Responsibilities and FSA Goal Plan electronically. If a manual form is used, it must be mailed to the client for signature. Once the completed manual FSA (STEP 6) is received, it must be saved in OnBase and the FSA Goal Plan details must be entered online in TuaPath.

Key techniques to develop a mutually-developed FSA Goal Plan include:

- Involve the participant. First, let the participant define the long-term goal of financial independence for the family. Offer the participant a clear picture of financial independence, if the participant is unsure. Discuss what STEP can do to support this goal.
- Focus on the goal. Independence from cash assistance and STEP is often the goal for most families. Getting a job, increasing employment or wages, or establishing disability payments is often the pathway.
- Avoid short-term goal(s) that are too large or too complex. Offer or encourage smaller short-term goal(s) that can be achieved quickly or easily, if the client is unsure. As the client achieves goal(s), their confidence will likely grow.
- When goal setting, also take into consideration:
 - What are the participant's interests?
 - What are the family's circumstances?
 - What was discovered during the Family Assessment?
 - Are there short-term challenges (potholes) that need to be resolved?
 - What other types of supports will be available to help while the participant is taking the action steps?

 Department of Children & Family Services <i>Building a Stronger Louisiana</i>	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-300-STEP Case Management Process
	Document No./Name	P-390-STEP Family Success Agreement
	Effective Date	February 15, 2024

Once the goal(s) and action steps are agreed upon, the participant or STEP Coach would enter these into the FSA Goal Plan using first person voice from the STEP participant's perspective.

Link each activity or action step to a specific TuaPath Timesheet Activity type.

The FSA Goal Plan may need changes when the participant:

- Has changes to the family's situation.
- Has an unexpected change (like homelessness or family violence issues).
- Achieves a goal or identifies a new goal or new pathway.
- Is within two weeks of completing a component or goal (to keep them continually participating).
- Gets a job.

Review and Revise sessions must be completed routinely as an ongoing process to measure the participant's progress, areas of need, supportive services, referrals, etc. These sessions must be documented in Person Notes to track the participant's process. The FSA Goal Plans may be revised, when needed.

Participants ** should take responsibility for arranging activities, services, and resources whenever possible. These include arranging for child care and transportation, registering for educational activities, and any other activities that lead to self-sufficiency.

III. FORMS AND INSTRUCTIONS

STEP 6 [Form](#) / [Instructions](#) Family Success Agreement

IV. REFERENCES

Code of Federal Regulations, Title 45: [Parts 261, 262, 263, and 265](#)
[Act 58, 2003 Reg. Session.](#)
[LAC 67:III.5725.](#)